

Under the Acacia Tree

A Love Novel by Walusimbi Leon (SGSS)

Chapter 1 — The Call

The news arrived on a Tuesday afternoon, delivered in the trembling voice of Grace's aunt, Mama Prossy, over a crackling phone line that seemed to know the weight of its message before it was spoken.

"Grace, my child," Mama Prossy had said, her voice breaking on every syllable, "Mama Agnes is gone."

The words hung in the air like dust motes in a sunbeam — suspended, unreal, refusing to settle. Grace stood in the center of her Kampala boutique, surrounded by mannequins draped in the latest

Ankara designs, bolts of colorful fabric stacked against the walls, and the lingering scent of her signature lavender room spray. Everything was exactly as it had been thirty seconds ago. But nothing was the same.

"How?" Grace finally managed, her voice barely a whisper.

"She had been feeling weak, but you know your grandmother. She refused to see a doctor. Said God would heal her in His time." Mama Prossy's voice cracked again. "She went peacefully, my dear. In her sleep. She looked... she looked at peace."

Grace sank onto a stool behind the counter, her legs suddenly unable to hold her. The boutique, her pride and joy — Nabatanzi Designs — felt foreign to her, the bright colors and elegant fabrics suddenly garish against the grey of her grief.

"I'll come," she said. "I'll leave tonight."

"Are you sure, my child? The bus from Kampala to Mbale—"

"I'll drive. I'll be there before morning."

Grace hung up and sat motionless for a long moment. Around her, the afternoon light streamed

through the large windows, casting golden rectangles on the polished concrete floor. A customer was browsing the rack of maxi dresses near the entrance, oblivious. The world, Grace realized with a pang, did not stop for grief.

She called her assistant, Brenda, who arrived within twenty minutes. Grace gave hurried instructions about the boutique, canceling appointments, rescheduling the meeting with the textile supplier from Tanzania. Brenda asked no questions — she simply nodded and wrote everything down.

Then Grace went home to pack.

Her apartment in Bukoto was a testament to the life she had built — ten years of hard work condensed into three bedrooms filled with sleek furniture, abstract art, and a walk-in closet that would make any fashionista weep with joy. She stood in the bedroom, a small travel bag open on the bed, and realized she didn't know what to pack for a funeral in the village.

She hadn't been back to Bududa in five years.

Five years since she had boarded a bus to Kampala with nothing but a duffel bag and a burning determination to never look back. Five years since she

had told her grandmother, "I'll visit soon," a promise that had stretched into months, then years, then silence.

The guilt sat heavy in her chest as she threw a few dresses into the bag. She added a pair of comfortable shoes, a scarf, a notebook. She didn't know what else to bring.

Her phone buzzed. A message from Richard, her boyfriend of two years:

"Meeting ran late. Dinner at 8? I'll pick you up."

Grace stared at the message for a long moment. Richard — handsome, ambitious, the son of a prominent Kampala businessman. He was the kind of man her mother would have called "a good catch." He drove a sleek BMW, wore tailored suits, and spoke with the confidence of someone who had never known hunger. Their relationship was comfortable, predictable, and utterly devoid of the kind of passion Grace had once dreamed of.

She typed back: "My grandmother passed away. I'm going to the village. I'll call you when I'm back."

The dots appeared immediately: "I'm so sorry, baby. Do you want me to come with you?"

Grace considered it. Richard in the village. Richard meeting her aunts and uncles. Richard sitting on a wooden bench under the mango tree, checking his watch, wondering when they could leave.

"No, it's okay. I need to do this alone. I'll call you."

She sent the message before she could change her mind.

The drive from Kampala to Mbale took approximately four hours on a good day, and this was not a good day. Grace left at six in the evening, just as the sun was beginning its descent over the city. She drove through the chaos of Jinja Road, past the massive roundabout at Spear Motors, and onto the highway that stretched eastward like a grey ribbon through the green countryside.

As the city fell away behind her, something shifted in Grace's chest. The tight knot of anxiety that she carried everywhere — the pressure of deadlines, the demands of clients, the constant need to prove herself — began to loosen, thread by thread.

She passed through Lugazi, where the sugar factory's smokestacks painted the sky white. Through

Jinja, where the Nile began its long journey to Egypt. Through Iganga, where women sold roasted maize by the roadside, the smoke curling into the twilight. Each town brought her closer to a past she had worked so hard to outrun.

By the time she reached Tororo, the sky had darkened completely, and the stars had emerged in a dazzling display that city lights had taught her to forget. She pulled over at a roadside stall and bought a bottle of water and a roasted cassava. The woman who sold it to her smiled with gaps where teeth should have been and said, "Traveling late, my daughter. God protect you."

Grace thanked her and got back in the car. The remaining stretch to Mbale passed in a blur of headlights and darkness. She thought about her grandmother's hands — gnarled, weathered, impossibly strong. Hands that had planted coffee trees, harvested beans, cooked meals for a dozen children, and held Grace's face when she cried. Hands that would never hold anything again.

The tears came then, silently, streaming down her cheeks as she drove. She didn't wipe them away. She let them fall.

Bududa was not a place that appeared on tourist maps. Tucked into the slopes of Mount Elgon, it was a scattering of red-earth compounds, banana plantations, and coffee farms that had been there for generations. The road from Mbale wound upward, unpaved and treacherous, carved into the mountainside by people who had learned to live with the land rather than against it.

Grace arrived just after midnight. The village was dark except for a few kerosene lamps flickering in the windows of her grandmother's compound. She parked the car at the bottom of the hill — there was no point trying to drive up the narrow path — and walked the rest of the way.

The compound was exactly as she remembered it. Three mud-and-wattle houses arranged around a central courtyard, where a massive acacia tree stood like a silent guardian. The tree had been there longer than anyone could remember. It had sheltered Grace's great-grandparents, her grandmother as a child, and then Grace herself. Its branches were wide enough to shade the entire compound, and its roots ran deep into the red earth, anchoring everything together.

Mama Prossy met her at the gate. She was Grace's maternal aunt, a sturdy woman in her fifties with a face that had weathered both joy and sorrow in equal measure. She embraced Grace without speaking, and for a long moment, they simply held each other.

"She's inside," Mama Prossy finally said. "We've kept her in her room. The funeral is on Saturday."

Grace nodded. She walked past the house where she had been born, past the kitchen where her grandmother had taught her to peel matooke, past the spot where the old goat used to be tethered. Everything was smaller than she remembered. The doorframes were lower. The windows were narrower. But the smell was the same — wood smoke, earth, and the sweet fragrance of ripening bananas.

She entered her grandmother's room alone.

Mama Agnes lay on a simple bed, her hands folded across her chest, a white cloth draped over her body. Her face was peaceful, the lines of worry and work softened by the stillness of death. She looked, Grace thought, like she was sleeping. Like she might open her eyes at any moment and say, "Grace, my child, you're home. Have you eaten?"

Grace sat on the stool beside the bed and wept.

The next morning, Grace woke to the sound of roosters and the smell of porridge cooking over an open fire. For a disorienting moment, she forgot where she was. The ceiling was too low, the walls too close, the mattress beneath her too thin. Then memory crashed over her like a wave.

She washed her face with water from a jerry can, changed into a simple black dress, and stepped outside. The compound was already bustling with activity. Women were preparing food in the outdoor kitchen, their voices rising and falling in the rhythm of shared grief. Men sat under the acacia tree, speaking in low tones. Children ran between the houses, their laughter a jarring contrast to the somber atmosphere.

And then Grace saw him.

He was standing near the coffee trees, talking to an elderly man she recognized as Uncle Sam — her grandmother's brother. He was taller than she remembered, broader in the shoulders, with the kind of quiet strength that didn't need to announce itself. He wore a simple button-down shirt and dark

trousers, and his face was etched with a calmness that seemed out of place in the chaos of mourning.

Musa Ssempijja.

Their eyes met across the compound, and time, which had moved in one direction for a decade, suddenly folded in on itself. Grace was eighteen again, standing under this same acacia tree, her heart racing as Musa smiled at her with those warm, knowing eyes.

He walked toward her, and Grace found that her feet would not move. She was rooted to the spot, caught between the past and the present, between the girl she had been and the woman she had become.

"Grace," he said, his voice deeper than she remembered, but just as gentle. "I'm sorry about Mama Agnes. She was..." He paused, searching for words. "She was a great woman."

"Thank you," Grace managed. "I didn't know you would be here."

"I came as soon as I heard." He looked at her, and there was no accusation in his eyes, no trace of the hurt she must have caused him when she left. Only a quiet, steady warmth. "It's good to see you."

Grace swallowed. "It's good to see you too, Musa."

And standing there, under the watchful branches of the acacia tree, Grace realized that coming home was not about returning to a place. It was about returning to the people who had shaped you, the memories that had made you, and the parts of yourself you had left behind.

The funeral was in three days. Three days of facing the past. Three days of sitting with grief. Three days of being close to the one person she had never been able to forget.

She had no idea if she was strong enough.

Chapter 2 — The Village

The days leading up to the funeral followed a rhythm that Grace had almost forgotten. In Kampala, time was money. Every minute had a purpose, a deadline, a deliverable. In Bududa, time was just... time. It flowed like the river at the bottom of the hill — steady, unhurried, indifferent to the frantic pace of the world beyond the mountain.

Grace woke each morning to the sound of birds and the distant lowing of cattle. She ate breakfast — porridge sweetened with honey, or chapati with chai — in the company of aunts and cousins she hadn't seen in years. She helped with the funeral preparations: folding chairs, arranging flowers, sweeping the compound until the red earth was smooth and clean.

And everywhere she went, she was aware of Musa.

He was a quiet presence at the edges of her vision. She would look up from chopping vegetables and see him carrying chairs across the compound. She would step outside for fresh air and find him talking to the

men under the acacia tree. Their paths crossed constantly, inevitably, as if the universe was determined to remind her of what she had walked away from.

On the second day, Grace found herself alone at the washing area behind the main house. She was scrubbing cooking pots — a task that would have been beneath her in Kampala, but here felt grounding, almost meditative. The sun was warm on her back, and the water was cool, and for a moment, she was able to simply exist, without grief or guilt or the weight of a decade.

"Need help?"

She looked up to find Musa standing at the corner of the house, a bucket in his hand. He smiled — that same gentle smile that had made her heart flutter when she was seventeen.

"I think I can handle a few pots," she said, smiling back.

"That's what I used to say when my mother made me wash dishes. I always broke at least one." He walked over and sat on the bench beside the washing area. "I'm not here to help. I'm here to keep you company."

Grace laughed — the first genuine laugh she had let out since arriving. "That's refreshingly honest."

"I've learned that honesty saves time." He looked at her, his eyes studying her face with a gentleness that made her feel seen in a way she hadn't felt in years. "How are you, Grace? Really?"

She paused, a pot halfway through being scrubbed. "I don't know," she admitted. "I'm sad about my grandmother. But I think I'm also sad about... everything else. The time I wasted. The distance I created. The person I used to be." She looked down at her hands, red from scrubbing. "I left here and never looked back. I thought that was strength. Now I'm not so sure."

"There's nothing wrong with leaving," Musa said quietly. "Everyone leaves at some point. The question is whether you remember where you came from."

"And what if you don't?"

He was quiet for a moment. "Then you find your way back."

Grace looked at him, really looked at him. He was thirty-two now, the same age as her. His face had matured — the softness of youth replaced by the

sharpness of experience. There were lines around his eyes that hadn't been there before, and a gray hair or two at his temples. But his eyes were the same. Warm, patient, full of a depth that she had never been able to fully explore.

"Why aren't you married, Musa?" The question slipped out before she could stop it. "You're a teacher, a good man, handsome—" She caught herself, feeling heat rise to her cheeks. "I mean, I'm just surprised no one has snatched you up."

Musa's smile didn't waver. "I've been waiting for the right person. Some things are worth waiting for."

The words hung between them, heavy with unspoken meaning. Grace turned back to the pots, scrubbing with renewed intensity.

"I should get back to work," she said, her voice slightly breathless.

"Of course." Musa stood. "Grace?"

She looked up.

"It's good to have you home."

He walked away, and Grace watched him go, her heart pounding in a way that felt both terrifying and exhilarating. She had come to Bududa to bury her

grandmother. She had not expected to find the ghost of a girl she used to be — or the man she had left behind.

Chapter 3 — The Old Stories

The night before the funeral, the family gathered under the acacia tree for a vigil. Lanterns hung from the branches, casting warm pools of light on the faces of those who had come to say goodbye. The air was thick with the smell of paraffin, wood smoke, and the sweet perfume of night-blooming jasmine.

Mama Prossy began the stories. She told of Mama Agnes's youth — how she had walked twenty kilometers to market every week, pregnant with her first child, carrying a basket of coffee beans on her head. How she had nursed her sick husband for three years before he passed. How she had raised seven children alone, farming the land with her own hands, refusing to remarry because, she said, "I already had the best."

"She was stubborn," Mama Prossy said, her voice thick with emotion. "Stubborn as a mule. But that stubbornness is what kept this family together."

Others shared stories. Uncle Sam remembered how Mama Agnes had once chased a thief out of the

compound with a burning log, her wrapper flying behind her as she ran. Cousin Sarah recalled the time Mama Agnes had walked fifteen kilometers to bring her medicine when she was sick as a child. Each story was a thread in the tapestry of a life that had touched so many.

Grace listened in silence. She had her own stories — a thousand small moments that no one else would remember. The way her grandmother would hum old songs while cooking, her voice off-key but full of joy. The way she would say, "Eat, my child, eat," as if food was the answer to every problem. The way she had held Grace's face before she left for Kampala and said, "Go, my child. But remember — this tree will always have roots for you."

As the night deepened, the gathering began to thin. Children were carried to bed, their heads lolling on their mothers' shoulders. The older men retired to their houses, their bones too tired for the late hour. Soon, only Grace and Musa remained under the acacia tree, the lanterns flickering in the gentle breeze.

"You're quiet tonight," Musa said.

"Just thinking."

"About what?"

Grace wrapped her arms around her knees. "About how I spent ten years building a life in Kampala, and none of those people know who I really am. They know Grace the designer. Grace the businesswoman. They don't know Grace from Bududa, the girl who used to climb this tree and pretend she was flying."

"Which Grace is more real?"

"I don't know anymore." She turned to look at him. "Do you ever feel like you're two different people?"

Musa considered the question. "Sometimes. There's the Musa who stands in front of a classroom every day, teaching children about the world. And there's the Musa who still dreams of the things he didn't do." He paused. "But I think we're all made of many parts. The key is to make peace with all of them."

"Have you made peace with yours?"

He looked at her, and in the soft lantern light, his eyes seemed to hold the entire night sky. "Some of them. Others... I'm still working on."

Grace felt the pull between them — familiar, magnetic, terrifying. She remembered the summer

before she left for Kampala. She and Musa had been inseparable. They would meet at the acacia tree every evening, sitting for hours, talking about everything and nothing. He had kissed her once, under the full moon — a kiss so gentle it had felt like a promise.

And then she had left without saying goodbye.

"Musa," she began, "about what happened—"

"Don't." He shook his head. "You don't have to apologize for leaving. You had dreams. You needed to chase them."

"But I never said goodbye. I never explained—"

"I understood." His voice was soft. "I didn't like it. But I understood."

Grace felt the tears prick at her eyes. "I'm sorry. I was young and scared and I thought if I stayed, I would never leave."

"And now?"

"Now I don't know what I thought." She wiped her eyes with the back of her hand. "I built a life that looks perfect from the outside. But inside, I feel like I'm still that girl, sitting under this tree, wondering who she's going to become."

Musa reached out and took her hand. His palm was warm and calloused — the hand of someone who worked with his hands, planted seeds, built things. It was so different from Richard's soft, manicured hands. It felt more real.

"You have time," he said. "You're still becoming."

They sat in silence, hands intertwined, as the lanterns burned low and the stars wheeled overhead. The acacia tree spread its branches above them, a silent witness to the connections that outlasted years and distance and silence.

Grace had come home to bury her grandmother. But as she sat with Musa under the watchful tree, she began to wonder if she had come home to find something else entirely.

Chapter 4 — The Funeral

The funeral was held on Saturday, under a sky that could not decide whether to rain or shine. The clouds hung low and heavy, and the air was thick with the smell of damp earth and crushed flowers. The entire village turned out, filling the compound with a sea of mourners dressed in black, white, and the deep burgundy of the family colors.

Grace stood at the front of the gathering, flanked by her aunts and uncles, as the pastor led the service. She heard the words — "ashes to ashes, dust to dust" — but they seemed to float above her, disconnected from the reality of her grandmother's body being lowered into the ground.

Musa stood among the crowd, his presence a quiet anchor in the storm of her grief. She caught his eye once, and he nodded — a small gesture, but enough to remind her that she was not alone.

The burial was followed by a feast — matooke, groundnut sauce, chicken, rice, and the ubiquitous Rolex that had become Uganda's unofficial national

dish. The mood shifted from somber to celebratory, as it always did at Ugandan funerals. People ate, laughed, shared memories, and reminded each other that death was not an ending but a transition.

Grace moved through the crowd, accepting condolences, thanking people for coming. She smiled, shook hands, embraced distant relatives she barely recognized. It was exhausting — the performance of grief, the expectation of stoicism, the pressure to be strong for everyone else.

By late afternoon, she needed to escape.

She slipped away from the compound and walked down the path that led to the coffee farm. The terraced hillsides stretched before her, green and orderly, the coffee plants heavy with cherry-red beans. Her grandmother had planted these trees, and her mother before her, and her grandmother before that. The land held the memory of generations.

She found a spot at the edge of the farm, where the mountain fell away to reveal a sweeping view of the valley below. The sun was beginning to set, painting the sky in shades of orange and pink. Grace sat on a rock and let the silence wash over her.

"Mind if I join you?"

She didn't need to turn around. She knew his voice.

"Please."

Musa sat beside her, close enough that she could feel the warmth radiating from his body. For a long moment, neither of them spoke.

"She loved this view," Grace finally said. "She used to bring me here when I was little. She would say, 'Grace, look at all of this. God is showing off.'"

"She was right." Musa's voice was soft. "He really was."

Grace laughed, a small, broken sound. "I'm going to miss her so much."

"I know."

"I didn't visit. I didn't call. I was so busy building my life that I forgot to live it with the people who mattered most."

"You're here now. That's what counts."

"Is it?" She turned to look at him, her eyes red and swollen. "I left her, Musa. I left everyone. I thought I was being strong, but I was just running."

"Running isn't always weakness. Sometimes it's survival." He looked at her with those steady eyes. "You were a girl with nothing but a dream. You had to run to catch it. Now that you've caught it, you get to decide what comes next."

"What if I don't know what comes next?"

"Then you sit here, on this mountain, and you figure it out one step at a time." He smiled. "You've always been good at figuring things out."

Grace leaned her head against his shoulder, and they sat together, watching the sunset paint the valley in gold and crimson. It was the most peaceful she had felt in years.

Chapter 5 — Richard

Richard arrived on Monday.

Grace had called him the night before, her voice exhausted but steady. "The funeral is over. You can come if you want. But Richard... this place is different. You need to be ready for that."

He had assured her he was ready. But as his sleek SUV — a borrowed vehicle, since his BMW would never survive the mountain roads — pulled up at the bottom of the hill, Grace knew that he was not.

Richard stepped out of the car wearing designer jeans and a polo shirt, his sunglasses pushed up on his head. He looked around the village with the kind of polite curiosity that people reserve for museums or safari parks.

"Wow," he said, as Grace walked down to meet him. "This is... really authentic."

"Authentic," Grace repeated, the word tasting strange in her mouth.

"I mean, the views are incredible. And the air — so fresh!" He took a deep breath, as if testing the oxygen quality. "I can see why you wanted to come back."

Grace led him up to the compound. Her aunts eyed him with polite suspicion. The children stared openly. Richard smiled his charming smile and shook hands with everyone, but Grace could see the discomfort behind his eyes. He was a city fish in a village pond, and he knew it.

"How long do you plan to stay?" he asked, as they sat under the acacia tree drinking chai.

"A few more days. There's paperwork to handle. My grandmother's property, her assets, the land—"

"The land?" Richard's eyebrows rose. "You're inheriting land?"

"I don't know yet. Mama Prossy says there's a will. We need to go to the district office to sort it out."

Richard leaned back in his chair, his expression thoughtful. "Interesting. I mean, land is always a good investment. You could sell it, use the capital for the boutique."

"Sell it?" Grace stared at him. "Richard, this land has been in my family for four generations. I'm not going to sell it."

"I'm just saying, you live in Kampala. You have a business. What are you going to do with a coffee farm in the middle of nowhere?"

The words hit Grace like a slap. "This 'middle of nowhere' is where I was born. Where my grandmother lived and died. Where my mother grew up."

"I know, babe. I'm not trying to offend you. I'm just being practical."

"Practical." Grace set down her cup. "You know what, I think I need some air."

She stood and walked away, her heart pounding. She could hear Richard calling after her, but she didn't stop. She walked past the houses, past the coffee farm, past the spot where she had watched the sunset with Musa, and kept going until she reached the edge of the village, where the road wound down the mountain toward the rest of the world.

She sat on a rock and buried her face in her hands.

Richard didn't understand. How could he? He had grown up in Kololo, the son of a wealthy businessman, attended by maids and drivers, his path smoothed by connections and money. He had never slept on a mud floor. He had never gone to bed hungry. He had never known the kind of poverty that made leaving feel like a matter of survival.

And he had never sat under an acacia tree with a boy who made him feel like the world was full of possibility.

That evening, Richard tried to make amends. He bought soda from the village shop and presented it to Grace like a peace offering. "I'm sorry," he said. "I was insensitive. This place means something to you, and I should respect that."

Grace accepted the soda, if not the apology. "It's fine."

"It's not fine. I'm an idiot." He sat beside her on the bench outside her grandmother's house. "Tell me about her. Your grandmother. What was she like?"

And so Grace told him. She told him about Mama Agnes's laugh, her cooking, her wisdom. She told him

about the lessons she had learned under this very acacia tree. She told him about the stories and the songs and the way her grandmother had believed in her when no one else did.

Richard listened. He nodded. He asked questions. And for a moment, Grace allowed herself to believe that he understood.

But then she saw him glance at his phone, checking for signal that didn't exist. She saw him brush a mosquito off his arm with barely concealed disgust. She saw him look at the pit latrine with the same expression she had seen on tourists at the national museum — curious, but relieved they didn't have to stay.

And she knew. She had been fooling herself.

Richard was a good man. But he was not her man. He was a chapter in her story, not the ending.

Chapter 6 — The Coffee Farm

The next morning, Grace woke before sunrise. She slipped out of bed while Richard was still asleep, pulled on a pair of rubber boots that she found by the door, and walked to the coffee farm.

The hillside was quiet, the only sound the chirping of birds and the rustle of leaves in the morning breeze. Grace walked between the rows of coffee plants, her fingers brushing against the glossy leaves, the ripe cherries. She had helped her grandmother harvest coffee as a child, her small hands working alongside Mama Agnes's weathered ones.

"Early bird."

She turned to find Musa at the edge of the farm, a machete in his hand. He was wearing a faded t-shirt and mud-caked boots, and he looked more at home than anyone she had seen in years.

"Couldn't sleep," she said.

"Neither could I." He walked over to join her. "I heard your boyfriend arrived."

"He's not—" She stopped. "Yes. He did."

Musa nodded, his expression unreadable. "He seems... successful."

"He is. Successful, handsome, charming. Everything a girl could want."

"But?"

Grace looked at the coffee plants, the terraced hillside, the morning mist rising from the valley below. "But he doesn't understand this place. He doesn't understand why it matters to me."

"Does that matter?"

"Yes." The word came out stronger than she expected. "Yes, it matters. This place made me. If he can't understand that, then he doesn't really understand me."

Musa was quiet for a moment. Then he said, "The coffee needs pruning. Do you want to help?"

And so Grace spent the morning doing what she had done as a child — working the land, her hands in the soil, her body moving in rhythm with the earth. Musa showed her which branches to cut, which cherries to pick, which plants needed more shade.

They worked side by side, their conversation flowing as easily as it had ten years ago.

"You're good at this," Musa said, as Grace expertly stripped a branch of its ripe cherries.

"My grandmother taught me. She said coffee was the crop that raised me."

"She was right." Musa wiped sweat from his brow. "This farm supports three families. Your grandmother's wisdom keeps giving."

Grace looked at the farm — the terraced hillside, the neat rows of plants, the careful irrigation system carved into the earth. She saw not just a farm, but a legacy. A story written in soil and sweat and love.

"Musa," she said slowly, "what would you do if you inherited this land?"

He considered the question. "I would keep farming it. Maybe expand, plant more varieties. There's a growing market for specialty Ugandan coffee. We could sell directly to roasters, cut out the middlemen. Get a better price for the farmers."

"You've thought about this."

"I've thought about a lot of things." He looked at her. "Some dreams I let go. Others... I held onto."

Grace felt the weight of his words. She looked at the farm, at the mountain, at the man standing beside her. And for the first time since she left Kampala, she allowed herself to imagine a different life — one where she was not Grace the designer, but Grace the farmer. Grace the builder of something that would outlast her.

Richard left the next day.

It was not a dramatic departure. No shouting, no accusations. Just a quiet acknowledgment that he did not belong here, and that Grace was not ready to leave.

"I'll call you when I'm back in town," he said, kissing her forehead.

"Okay."

"You take care of yourself."

"I will."

He drove away, his SUV bumping down the mountain road, and Grace watched him go with a strange mixture of relief and sadness. She had just ended a two-year relationship, and she felt... nothing.

Or rather, she felt the absence of the pain she expected. Maybe that was the real tragedy — not that she was losing Richard, but that she had never truly had him to begin with.

Chapter 7 — The Will

On Wednesday, Grace went to the district office in Mbale with Mama Prossy and Uncle Sam. The building was a colonial relic, its paint peeling, its ceiling fans creaking. They waited for two hours in a stuffy corridor before a clerk finally called them in.

The will was simple. Mama Agnes had few possessions — some land, a few cows, her house. But what she had, she left to Grace.

"To my granddaughter, Grace Nabatanzi, I leave the coffee farm at Bududa, with all its trees and the land on which they grow, and the house in which I was born and died. Use it well, my child. It has taken care of me, and it will take care of you."

Grace read the words three times, tears streaming down her face. She had expected nothing. She had come to Bududa expecting to grieve, to make arrangements, to return to Kampala and continue her life.

But Mama Agnes had other plans.

"You're a landowner now," Mama Prossy said, squeezing her hand. "Your grandmother always said you would come back. She believed in you."

Chapter 8 — Conversations Under the Tree

The days that followed were a blur of emotions. Grace walked the boundaries of her land, learning every inch of the farm she had inherited. She talked to the neighbors, learned about the challenges facing the coffee farmers — climate change, market volatility, the aging of the farming population.

She also spent time with Musa.

They met under the acacia tree every evening, as they had done when they were young. Sometimes they talked for hours. Sometimes they sat in comfortable silence, watching the stars appear one by one.

"Do you ever think about what would have happened if I had stayed?" Grace asked one evening.

Musa was quiet for a long time. "I used to. A lot. I imagined all the lives we could have had."

"And now?"

"Now I realize that life doesn't work that way. You can't go back and choose the other path. You can only move forward."

"But what if moving forward means going back?"

He looked at her, his eyes searching hers. "What are you saying, Grace?"

She took a deep breath. "I'm saying that I've been asking myself what I really want. And every time I ask, the answer is the same. I want to stay."

"Stay here? In the village?"

"Yes." She laughed, the sound surprised out of her. "I know it sounds crazy. I have a business in Kampala. A life. But I've realized that I built that life for someone I used to be. I don't know who I am now, but I think... I think I want to find out here."

Musa was silent, and Grace felt her heart plummet.

"You don't have to say anything," she said quickly. "I'm not expecting—"

"I've been waiting for you to say that for ten years."

She looked at him, and he was smiling — a real smile, the kind that reached his eyes and made them shine.

"Ten years is a long time to wait," she whispered.

"You're worth it."

He reached for her hand, and she let him take it. Under the acacia tree, with the moon rising over Mount Elgon, Grace felt something click into place — a piece of herself that she hadn't even realized was missing.

Chapter 9 — The City Calls

But leaving Kampala was not simple.

The phone calls started almost immediately. Brenda, her assistant, with a dozen questions about the boutique. Clients wanting updates on their orders. Suppliers needing payments. The landlord wanting next month's rent.

Grace handled each call with patience, but each conversation pulled her back into a world she was trying to leave. She found herself standing in her grandmother's house, surrounded by mud walls and kerosene lamps, negotiating with a textile manufacturer in India. The juxtaposition was jarring.

"You're stretched thin," Musa observed one afternoon, finding her on the phone for the third time in an hour.

"I have to figure out what to do with the boutique. I can't run it from here."

"Could you sell it?"

The question hung in the air. Sell Nabatanzi Designs — the business she had poured her heart and soul into for five years. The name she had built from nothing.

"I don't know if I can," she admitted. "It's my baby."

"Babies grow up." Musa sat beside her. "They leave home."

She laughed, despite herself. "When did you become so wise?"

"I teach children. You either get wise or you go crazy."

She leaned against him, and he put his arm around her. The simplicity of it — the ease of his touch — made her heart ache.

Chapter 10 — The Offer

A week later, Grace received an unexpected visitor.

Richard had returned.

He stood at the bottom of the hill, dressed in a suit, his car gleaming in the afternoon sun. Grace walked down to meet him, her heart pounding with uncertainty.

"I've been thinking," he said, without preamble. "About us. About what you said. I don't understand this place, but I want to. I want to understand you."

"Richard—"

"Let me finish." He took a breath. "I talked to my father. He has connections in agribusiness. We could turn this farm into something profitable. Set up a processing facility, export directly. You could keep the land, honor your grandmother's legacy, and still have a life in Kampala. We could make it work."

Grace stared at him. "You want to industrialize my grandmother's farm?"

"I want to help you. I want to be part of your life."

She looked at Richard — successful, generous, trying so hard to fit into a world he couldn't understand. He was offering her a compromise. A middle ground. A life that bridged her two worlds.

It would be easy to say yes.

"Richard, I..." She paused, searching for the right words. "I appreciate what you're trying to do. But I don't need a compromise. I need a choice. And I've already made it."

His face fell. "You're choosing this place over me?"

"I'm choosing myself. For the first time in a long time, I know what I want. And what I want is here."

Richard nodded slowly. "I thought you might say that." He smiled, but it didn't reach his eyes. "I hope you find what you're looking for, Grace."

"Thank you. I hope you do too."

He got back in his car and drove away. Grace watched until the dust settled, then turned and walked back up the hill, toward the acacia tree, toward Musa, toward the life she was choosing for herself.

Chapter 11 — The Announcement

That evening, Grace gathered her family under the acacia tree.

"I have something to tell you," she said. Her aunts, uncles, and cousins looked at her expectantly. "I'm staying."

"Staying?" Mama Prossy's voice rose with surprise. "Staying where?"

"Here. In Bududa. I'm going to run the coffee farm. Full time."

The compound erupted. Some gasped. Some laughed. Others exchanged worried glances.

"Grace, my child, have you thought about this?" Uncle Sam asked. "Farming is hard work. You've built a life in Kampala."

"I know, Uncle. But I've realized that the life I built in Kampala was a copy of someone else's dream. I don't want to wake up in twenty years and realize I've been living a life that wasn't mine."

"But the boutique—"

"I'm going to sell it. Or rather, I'm going to give Brenda the opportunity to buy it. She's been running it for years, and she deserves the chance to own it."

Mama Prossy shook her head. "Your grandmother would be proud, you know. She always said you had the land in your blood."

Grace felt tears prick her eyes. "I hope so."

The family gathered around her, hugging her, blessing her, sharing their thoughts and fears and hopes. It was overwhelming and beautiful and terrifying.

And through it all, Musa stood at the edge of the gathering, watching her with a smile that said everything words could not.

Chapter 12 — Learning the Land

The next few weeks were a crash course in coffee farming.

Musa became her teacher, as he had been for so many children in the village school. He showed her how to prune, how to fertilize, how to identify pests and diseases. He introduced her to the other farmers in the cooperative, men and women who had been working the land their entire lives.

"The soil here is good," he said one morning, kneeling to examine a plant. "But it needs care. Coffee is not like other crops. It demands patience."

"I'm not very patient," Grace admitted.

"You'll learn." He smiled up at her. "The land teaches patience."

And it did. Grace learned to wake before dawn, to work until her muscles ached, to appreciate the small victories — a plant that had recovered from disease, a patch of soil that had been successfully terraced, a harvest that exceeded expectations.

She also learned about the challenges. The roads that became impassable during the rainy season. The middlemen who paid pennies for coffee that would sell for dollars in Europe. The changing climate that brought unpredictable rains and new pests.

"There's so much to fix," she said one evening, exhausted and discouraged.

"Then fix it," Musa said simply. "One day at a time."

Chapter 13 — Growing Closer

As the weeks passed, Grace and Musa's relationship deepened.

They worked together, ate together, spent every evening under the acacia tree. They talked about everything — their childhoods, their dreams, their fears. Grace told him about her father, who had died when she was young. Musa told her about his mother, who had passed away five years ago, leaving him alone in the world.

"I thought I would be alone forever," he said one night. "I made peace with it."

"And now?"

"Now I don't want to be alone anymore."

He reached for her hand, and she let him take it. The moon was full overhead, casting silver light on the compound.

"I love you, Grace. I've loved you since we were children. I never stopped."

She turned to face him, her heart pounding. "I love you too, Musa. I think I've been running toward you my whole life, even when I was running away."

He kissed her then — a gentle, reverent kiss that tasted like forever.

Chapter 14 — The Proposal

A month later, Musa proposed under the acacia tree.

He didn't have a ring — not a real one. He presented her with a simple band woven from coffee twigs, his hands trembling slightly.

"It's not much," he said. "But it's made from the farm. From your grandmother's legacy. From everything that brought you back to me."

Grace laughed and cried at the same time. "It's perfect."

"Will you marry me, Grace Nabatanzi?"

"Yes. A thousand times yes."

The family erupted with joy. Mama Prossy cried. Uncle Sam laughed and clapped Musa on the back. The children ran in circles, cheering.

And the acacia tree stood witness, its branches spreading wide, sheltering the lovers who had found their way back to each other.

Chapter 15 — A New Beginning

The wedding was held in the village, under the acacia tree. Grace wore a dress she had designed herself — a beautiful blend of traditional gomesi and modern elegance. Musa wore a simple suit, a flower pinned to his lapel.

The pastor spoke of love, of commitment, of the journey that had brought them to this moment. The family sang and danced and feasted. The children threw flower petals.

And at the center of it all, Grace and Musa held hands, their eyes locked on each other, their hearts beating as one.

"Under this tree," Grace whispered, as they danced, "I learned what love means."

"Under this tree," Musa replied, "I learned to wait for you."

They kissed, and the village cheered.

Epilogue — Roots

One year later, Grace stood on the hillside above the coffee farm, surveying the land that was now her life. The trees were healthy. The harvest had been good. The cooperative had secured a direct trade agreement with a roaster in Europe, cutting out the middlemen and doubling the farmers' income.

And at the center of the compound, the acacia tree still stood, its branches reaching toward the sky.

"It's beautiful," Musa said, coming up behind her and wrapping his arms around her waist.

"It's home." She leaned back against him, feeling the steady beat of his heart against her back. "Finally."

"How does it feel? Being back where you started?"

"It doesn't feel like starting. It feels like arriving."

They stood together on the hillside, looking at the land that was theirs, the life they had built, the love that had brought them home.

Somewhere down the hill, a child laughed. The coffee plants rustled in the breeze. And the acacia tree stood guard, as it had for generations, watching over the place where roots ran deep and love grew strong.

THE END

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— THE END —